recruitment of the army, according to the agreement, has not been completed as yet'.[70]

Only at the end of April were orders finally despatched to General Avitabile, Ranjit's Governor in Peshawar, to organise a regiment of local Muslims to assist with the invasion.[71] By mid-May, when Shah Shuja and the main army were already gorging on the peaches, apricots and apples of Kandahar, only one battalion of irregular cavalry – around 650 sowars [cavalrymen] – had yet turned up in Peshawar.[72] Throughout May, as the Khyber chiefs sent down further requests for advance presents and payments – 'I have been successful winning over the people of my hills,' wrote one chief, 'and Rs 20,000 will now be required' – Ranjit sent a message to the now frantic Wade, telling him that there was no hurry and could he come back to Lahore for further consultations about the planned attack?[73]

A month later, Wade received worse news still: Ranjit Singh had taken to his bed 'after a fainting fit'; he died on 27 June, at the age of fifty-eight. His last act was to make a series of huge charitable disbursements. 'Two hours before he died he sent for all his jewels,' reported William Osborne, 'and gave the famous diamond called the Mountain of Light to a temple, his celebrated string of pearls to another, and his favourite horses, with all their jewelled trappings, to a third. His four wives, all very handsome, burnt themselves with his body, as did five of his Cashmerian slave girls . . . Everything was done to prevent it, but in vain . . .'[74]

In Simla, Emily Eden, who had been celebrating the taking of Kandahar – 'Our ball tomorrow will be very gay, and I have just arranged to stick up a large "Kandahar" opposite the other illuminations' – was now horrified by the fate of the 'Mrs Runjeets' she had visited only a few months earlier. 'We thought them so beautiful and so merry,' she wrote. 'The deaths of those poor women is so melancholy, they were such gay young creatures, and they died with the most obstinate courage.' She added: 'I begin to think that the "hundred wife system" is better than the mere one wife rule; they are more attached and faithful.'[75]

It was Wade who immediately realised the much more serious implication for the invasion of Afghanistan. If it had been difficult to gather the promised army when Ranjit Singh was alive, it was going to be next to impossible now he was gone: few of Ranjit's noblemen had shared his enthusiasm for an alliance with the British, and with the succession disputed